

Phonology and Morphology of Biblical Hebrew

An Introduction

Joshua Blau

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Abbreviations

1CS	first-person common singular
2FP	second-person feminine plural, etc.
2MS	second-person masculine singular, etc.
3CD	third-person common dual
Akk	Akkadian
Arab	(Classical) Arabic
Aram	Aramaic
BHeb	Biblical Hebrew
D	The theme with doubled second radical (<i>pi^{cc}el</i> , <i>pu^{cc}al</i> , <i>hitpa^{cc}el</i>)
ET	English translation
Heb	Hebrew
PS	Proto-Semitic
Ug	Ugaritic

Bibliographical Abbreviations

BDB = Brown, Driver, and Briggs 1907
 Bergsträsser = Bergsträsser 1918–29
 CAT = Dietrich, Loretz, and Sanmartín 1995
Grammar = Blau, *A Grammar of Biblical Hebrew*², 1993
Middle Arabic = Blau, *Studies in Middle Arabic and Its Judaeo-Arabic Variety* (Jerusalem: Magnes, 1988)
Studies = Blau, *Studies in Hebrew Linguistics* (Jerusalem: Magnes, 1996; in Hebrew)
Topics = J. Blau, *Topics in Hebrew and Semitic Linguistics* (Jerusalem: Magnes, 1998)
UT = Gordon, *Ugaritic Textbook* (Rome: Pontifical Biblical Institute, 1965)

Phonetic Symbols

a (*pataḥ* ַ) open front vowel, unrounded
ă (*ḥaṭaf pataḥ* ֿ) ultra-short open unrounded front vowel, etc.
b̥ the fricative counterpart of *b*, phonetically identical to *v*
C (any) consonant
d̥ the conventional sign for Arabic ض, originally an emphatic fricative lateral (ṣ₃)

<i>d</i>	voiced <i>th</i> ; also the fricative counterpart of <i>d</i>
<i>ḏ</i>	voiced emphatic <i>th</i> , <i>ṣ</i> ₃ , in Arabic <i>ḏ</i> (which is conventionally transcribed by <i>z</i>)
<i>e</i>	(<i>ṣere</i> <i>ִ</i>) a half-closed unrounded front vowel
<i>ḡ</i>	(<i>ḡ</i>) the fricative counterpart of <i>g</i> , phonetically identical to <i>ḡ</i>
<i>ḡ</i>	voiced fricative velar (Arabic <i>ġ</i>), phonetically identical to <i>ḡ</i>
<i>ḥ</i>	ḥ, voiceless fricative pharyngeal
<i>ḥ</i>	see <i>x</i>
<i>k</i>	the fricative counterpart of <i>k</i> , phonetically identical to <i>x</i>
<i>o</i>	(<i>ḥolam</i> <i>ֻ</i> ; in Sephardic tradition, this is the pronunciation of <i>qamaṣ</i> <i>qaṭan</i> as well) rounded half-closed back vowel
<i>p̄</i>	the fricative counterpart of <i>p</i> , phonetically identical to <i>f</i>
<i>q</i>	uvular voiceless plosive
<i>ś</i>	š, originally voiceless lateral sibilant, today pronounced as <i>s</i> (BHeb ש)
<i>t</i>	voiceless <i>th</i> ; also the fricative counterpart of <i>t</i>
<i>V</i>	(any) vowel
<i>x</i>	voiceless fricative velar (Arabic <i>ḫ</i> , also transcribed <i>h</i>), phonetically identical to <i>k</i>
<i>æ</i>	(<i>segol</i> <i>ֶ</i>) half-open front vowel without lip-rounding
<i>ǣ</i>	(<i>ḥaṭaf segol</i> <i>ֵ</i>) ultra-short half-open front vowel without lip-rounding
<i>ɔ</i>	(<i>qamaṣ</i> <i>ֹ</i>) rounded half-open back vowel (or perhaps it was spread?), according to the Tiberian pronunciation (<i>ā</i> according to the Sephardic pronunciation)
<i>ɔ̄</i>	(<i>ḥaṭaf qamaṣ</i> <i>ֵ</i>) ultra-short half-closed rounded back vowel
<i>ə</i>	central vowel (mobile <i>šwa</i> , which, however, in the Tiberian tradition is usually pronounced <i>ǣ</i>)
ʔ	ʔ, a pharyngeal voiceless fricative (glottal stop)
ʕ	ʕ, a pharyngeal voiced fricative
ˈ	indicates that the vowel is stressed; it has been consistently applied to mark penult stress
*	marks a reconstructed form
-	over a letter marking a vowel indicates that the vowel is long; over <i>ת פ כ ב ג ד</i> it (optionally) marks their spirant pronunciation; over <i>ה ו א</i> it (optionally) denotes its use as vowel letter
˘	over a vowel indicates that the vowel is ultra-short
.	dot under a consonant indicates its emphatic pronunciation
˙	under <i>b g d k p t</i> marks their spirant pronunciation; for typographical reasons, this line is put above <i>g p</i> : <i>ḡ p̄</i> .
””	in quotations of the Hebrew text denotes the Tetragrammaton

Publisher's Foreword

This book has been in development over an extraordinarily long time. In a conversation in Jerusalem in 2002, Prof. Michael P. O'Connor and Prof. Richard C. Steiner originated the idea of publishing an English translation of Prof. Joshua Blau's study on the phonology and morphology of Biblical Hebrew. This discussion occurred while Prof. O'Connor was participating in an international research group on the subject of Biblical Hebrew in Its Northwest Semitic Setting (the papers that this group presented were eventually published as *Biblical Hebrew in Its Northwest Semitic Setting*, ed. Steven Fassberg and Avi Hurvitz; Jerusalem: Magnes / Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2006). Prof. O'Connor suggested that the English translation of Prof. Blau's work appear in the Linguistic Studies in Ancient West Semitic series he co-edited with Prof. Cynthia L. Miller, and Prof. Blau was most agreeable to this proposal.

The manuscript of the English translation arrived in late 2002, and it was apparent that some editorial and bibliographical work was needed to achieve what both Prof. Blau and Prof. O'Connor believed the book could accomplish. Prof. O'Connor himself undertook this work and, in addition to his other duties in the Dept. of Semitics at the Catholic University of America, completely reworked the bibliography, reorganized major sections of the discussion, and otherwise personally oversaw the entire project. This took no small amount of time, and other responsibilities often delayed his work. The first portions of the book were sent in proof to Prof. Blau in 2005, and work on the remainder proceeded in fits and starts.

Then, in June 2007, Michael O'Connor died after a short illness, a death that shocked all of us who knew him. At that point, his editorial work was only perhaps half completed. Picking up the pieces was no minor task; much of the work had to be completed by O'Connor's series co-editor, Prof. Miller. Various staff members at Eisenbrauns and I also read the manuscript and proofs for consistency and organization, prepared the paradigms and indexes, and managed much trans-Atlantic correspondence. The net effect of O'Connor's tragic death, however, was that there were still more delays. Prof. Blau, throughout all of this, has been unfailingly patient and kind; it has been a pleasure to work with him.

Now that the work is complete, we all feel certain that the finished work is an appropriate testimony to the distillation of a life's work in Biblical Hebrew (on the part of Prof. Blau) and the memory of a dearly beloved friend (Prof. O'Connor).

Jim Eisenbraun,
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